



WAS A.J. LIEBLING RIGHT ABOUT CHICAGO?

Arguably nothing in 100 years of The New Yorker landed on Chicago with more oomph than the infamous 1952 profile of the city. It's time for a second reading. **A+E**

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Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, JUNE 29, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM



ROUTE 66 ONE CENTURY, ONE ROAD

JOURNEY'S END

Eight states, 21 days and 2,448 miles later, the Great American Road Trip comes to a conclusion



Above: Tourists stop along Route 66 in downtown El Reno, Oklahoma, on June 14. **At top:** Eric Wagner, with the state tourism office, photographs Ding Peng, from China, with giant "muffler man" fiberglass statues collected at the American Giants museum in Atlanta, Illinois, on June 21. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

By Jonathan Bullington and E. Jason Wambsgans
Chicago Tribune

After three weeks on the road, Tribune journalists Jonathan Bullington and E. Jason Wambsgans completed their Route 66 journey in Chicago — the cornerstone of the historic highway. As they explored the enduring appeal of America's "Main Street" ahead of its centennial next year, the famed route took them to quirky roadside attractions, mom-and-pop diners and struggling neighborhoods across three time zones. In their final days, including a 300-mile stretch through Illinois, Bullington and Wambsgans continued to meet the people and places that give Route 66 its soul. Join them on their last legs:

Hamburgers so savory, they can make you cry

EL RENO, Okla. — The air downtown smells of grilled onions, wafting from the flat tops of three Route 66 restaurants that have helped give this small town about 25 miles west of Oklahoma City a distinct culinary identity. They're called fried onion burgers. Plenty of places put onions on burgers. Few have been doing it as long, or as well, as they do here. "They're not like any burger," said Lyndsay Bayne, 48, the city's public information and marketing manager. "It's hard to explain. You have to eat one." A few years before the country plunged into the Great Depression and the nascent Route 66 ferried Dust Bowl refugees west,

Turn to Route 66, Page 10

Violent crime in city has big drop

Year-to-date homicides fall to level not seen in a decade in Chicago

By Sam Charles and Caroline Kubzansky
Chicago Tribune

Major cities across the country, including New York and Los Angeles, have seen significant dips in violent crime since the unrest of 2020, when protests, riots and looting followed the killing of George Floyd by a police officer in Minneapolis and the COVID-19 pandemic was taking hold. Now Chicago finds itself firmly in that group. The city is poised to close the first half of the year with its steepest statistical drop in recent memory, with fewer than 200 homicides in the first six months of a calendar year for the first time in more than a decade, according to city and county figures. And 2025 would be the fourth year in a row that Chicago violence totals have decreased, despite President Donald Trump and others holding the city out as a national punching bag on violent crime.

Police and experts have not singled out one particular cause of the improvement. Police Superintendent Larry Snelling said his department's strategy has been to intensify efforts to tamp down hot spots. "We've broken down certain locations where we know, number one, there's historic violence that occurs in those areas," Snelling told the Tribune on Thursday, "But we also look at current trends of violence in particular areas, and we focus by making sure that we're allocating resources for those locations." "If we're going to be serious about saving people's lives, then we need to look where people's lives are being taken," he added.

Turn to Crime, Page 4

INSIDE: Sharp drop in arrests, other long-term crime trends shown on new Cook County data dashboard. **Chicagoland, Page 4**

INSIDE



Okoro, left, and Ball. **AP 2021**

Bulls move forward on reshaping roster

In the first trade of the summer for the Bulls, the team sent point guard Lonzo Ball to the Cavaliers in exchange for forward Isaac Okoro, ESPN reports. **Chicago Sports**

Republican senators revamp Trump's bill

The Senate launched a rare Saturday session as the GOP races to pass a package of tax breaks, spending cuts and bolstered deportation funds. **Nation & World**

Heat wave shows gaps in city's cooling center network

By Lily Carey and Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Record high nighttime temperatures, a dangerously high heat index and intense humidity swept through Chicago from June 21 to 23, marking the city's first major heat wave of the summer. Ahead of the heat wave, Mayor Brandon Johnson told residents at a June 20 news conference that the city was "prepared to demonstrate the full force of government" by offering city-run cooling centers. The city's website promotes 288 cooling center locations across the city, which are intended to "offer residents air-conditioned refuge" during extreme heat advisories. Of those, 110 are outdoor "splash pads" — water features operated by the

Turn to Cooling, Page 5



Ava Montenegro, 9, plays in a splash pad in Chicago's Humboldt Park on Wednesday. **CHRIS SWEDA/TRIBUNE**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 94 Low 74

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 20

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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